

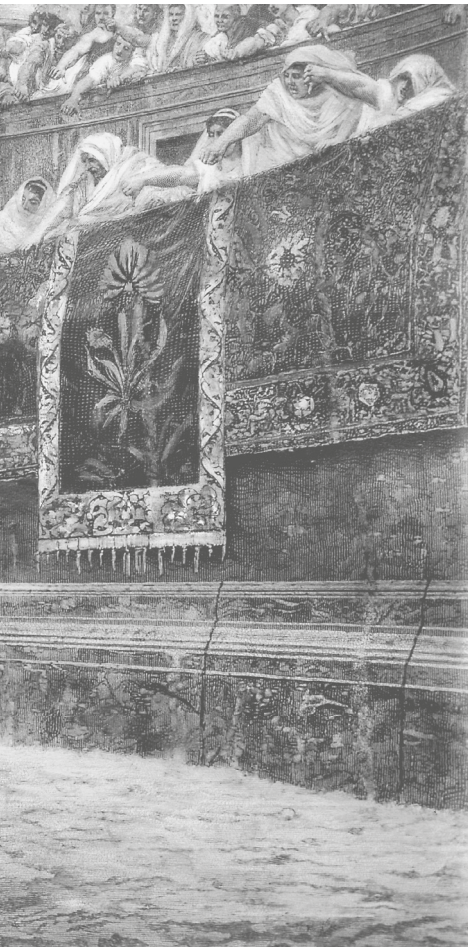
A taste for violence

Gladiators were a Roman fashion—the world has seen nothing like them before or since. In towns and cities throughout the Roman Empire, arenas of all sizes were built to stage shows for the public—especially gladiatorial games. These violent, bloody contests were usually the most popular event in a town's social calendar, a chance for people to see their

heroes in action. Roman audiences were as happy to watch gladiators spilling each other's blood as they were to watch actors perform a comedy play at the theater. The Romans thought that gladiator fights were a perfectly acceptable form of entertainment. It was gory but glamorous, and they loved it. It's only later generations—and that includes us—who think of them as horrible acts of violence, the nastiest, cruelest blood sport ever invented.

Bringers of good luck

The Roman liking for watching fighting and killing in public lasted for around 500 years. It's not surprising then that gladiators played such a big part in Roman society. All manner of superstitions and beliefs grew up around them. For example, during a marriage ceremony, it was the custom on the wedding day for the bride to part her hair with the tip of a spear—and if it had belonged to a gladiator killed in the arena, she would be blessed



THIS PICTURE CAPTURES THE DRAMA OF THE ARENA. A FALLEN GLADIATOR LOOKS TO THE CROWD TO SEE IF THEY WILL SPARE HIS LIFE. THEIR "THUMBS DOWN" RESPONSE SIGNALS THAT THE LOSER SHOULD DIE.